

A FREE SELF-AUDIT FROM KAGISO SHABANGU

The Interview Prep Checklist

Fifteen checks that tell you if you are ready,
before you walk in.

Score your readiness in about ten minutes. Then close the gaps that
matter.

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Before you start

Hello. I am Kagiso Shabangu, your career development and personal brand coach. An interview is rarely lost on the day. It is lost in the days before, when preparation is thin and nerves fill the gap. Preparation is what turns those nerves into confidence.

This is a readiness self-audit, not an answer bank. By the end you will know exactly where you are ready and where you are exposed. It does not hand you the answers. It shows you what to prepare before you walk in.

-  **Green.** You are ready on this.
-  **Amber.** Half ready. Worth firming up.
-  **Red.** A gap that could cost you the offer.

Work through the fifteen checks. Tick one light for each. When you reach the end, count your red marks. That number tells you how ready you are, and what to prepare first.

SECTION A

Logistics and setup

The interview can be lost before it starts, on a dropped call or a late arrival. These five checks remove the avoidable risks.

1 You have confirmed the date, time, format, and platform, and you know which stages to expect.

- | | |
|---|---|
|  Green All confirmed, and you know whether it is telephonic, virtual, a panel, or includes an assessment. |  |
|  Amber You know the time, but you are unsure of the format or the stages. |  |
|  Red You have not confirmed the details, or you are unsure how to join. |  |

2 For a virtual interview, you have tested your device, camera, audio, and connection, and you have backup power and data in a quiet, well-lit space.

- Green** Tested and ready, with a backup plan for power and data. ☐
- Amber** Set up, but no backup if the power or signal drops. ☐
- Red** Not tested, or no quiet, reliable space arranged. ☐

3 You have planned to arrive early.

- Green** Logged in five to ten minutes ahead online, or ten to fifteen minutes early in person, with transport sorted. ☐
- Amber** A plan, but a tight one with no margin for delays. ☐
- Red** No arrival or travel plan yet. ☐

4 Your documents are ready, with certified copies where this employer requires them.

- Green** CV, ID, qualifications, and references ready, and you have checked this employer's recency rule for certified copies. ☐
- Amber** Documents gathered, but not certified or checked against the requirement. ☐
- Red** Documents not yet ready. ☐

5 Your attire matches the sector, and your public profiles look professional.

- Green** Dressed to the sector standard, formal for banking, law, and government, smart for tech and creative, and your profiles are clean. ☐
- Amber** Outfit sorted, but you are unsure it fits this sector. This is a judgement call. ☐
JUDGEMENT CALL
- Red** No outfit planned, or your public profiles need attention. ☐

SECTION B

What you bring to the room

Once you are set up, the interview is yours to win on substance. These five checks are what a panel is actually weighing.

6

You have researched the company beyond its website.

-  **Green** You know what they do, recent news, their values, and how this role fits. 
-  **Amber** You have skimmed the website, but no deeper research. 
-  **Red** Little or no research done. 

7

You have re-read the advert and matched your experience to its top three requirements.

-  **Green** You can point to evidence for each of the main requirements. 
-  **Amber** You have read it, but not mapped your experience to it. 
-  **Red** You have not revisited the advert. 

8

You have real examples ready for problem-solving, leadership, teamwork, and pressure.

-  **Green** Specific, true examples you can tell clearly, drawn from work or study. 
-  **Amber** A few examples in mind, but not thought through. 
-  **Red** No prepared examples. 

9

You have two or three thoughtful questions ready to ask the panel.

-  **Green** Researched questions that show real interest in the role and the business. 
-  **Amber** One generic question, such as asking only about salary or leave. 
-  **Red** No questions prepared. 

10

You can explain why you are moving, and speak about past employers without criticising them.



Green A clear, positive reason for the move, and a professional way to discuss the past.



Amber A reason, but it leans on what was wrong before.



Red No clear answer, or you tend to speak negatively about past roles.



SECTION C

The South African specifics

These are the checks the imported interview guides miss, and the ones that catch local candidates out.

11

You have researched a realistic salary range (total cost to company) and can state your expectation with a reason.



Green A researched CTC range, and you can give it with a reason.



Amber A rough figure, but no market research behind it.



Red No idea what to ask for, and you will still be asked.



12

You have decided how you will explain any gap or retrenchment honestly and factually.



Green A clear, honest account of any gap over six months, and what you did during it.



Amber You know it may come up, but you have not decided how to put it.



Red A gap you are hoping is not noticed.



13

You know whether this role needs a criminal, credit, or qualification check, and you are ready to give written consent.



Green You know what checks apply and you are prepared to consent.



Amber You are not sure whether checks apply to this role.



Red Checks may apply and you are not prepared for them.



14

You are ready for the interview to move between formal and conversational tones while staying clear.

- ☒ **Green** Comfortable adjusting your tone while keeping your points clear. ☐
- ☐ **Amber** You can do it, but it makes you nervous. ☐
- ☐ **Red** You have not thought about this. ☐

15

You have a plan to stay calm if load-shedding or a technical fault interrupts, and you are ready to send a brief thank-you note afterwards.

- ☒ **Green** A plan to communicate calmly if something drops, and a short thank-you note ready to send. ☐
- ☐ **Amber** One of the two is sorted, not both. ☐
- ☐ **Red** No plan for a disruption, and no follow-up intended. ☐

One last pass. The night before, read the advert one more time, lay out your documents and your outfit, and confirm how you will join or where you will go. Walking in prepared is what steadies the nerves.

Now count your reds

0 to 1 red

You are ready. Do a final run through your examples and your questions, and walk in with confidence.

2 to 4 reds

You are close, but there are gaps that could cost you. Work through your reds before the interview, not on the day.

5 or more reds

You are not ready yet, and it is better to know that now than in the room. Each red is a clear, fixable thing to prepare. Start with the section that worries you most.

The next step

If you would like to prepare properly, that is what I do. I help people get interview-ready, from the examples they tell to the way they handle the hard questions. See how to work with me at coachkagiso.co.za/work-with-me. And if you reply to the email this came in on and tell me your score, I read those myself.

Show up. Stand out. Level up.

Your career matters. Keep elevating.

Kagiso

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